

Forward

by Jonny Dorais

I lived on a humongous continent. It was over ten thousand miles wide and ten thousand miles long, and I was lost. A small box of matches lay cozily in my only shirt pocket. That and the rest of my tattered clothes were all I had. I had spent the past three days walking down a meadow, trailing a rusty railroad with no intention of stopping. The tracks never seemed to end; yet for some dumbfounded reason, I followed it, carrying the hope of a blind child.

Why? No one ever knew, because no one ever asked me. Until now.

The time was an hour before sundown. I carefully tiptoed on the rail of the train tracks, balancing myself like a kid trying to act like a trapeze in a playground. My focus was so invested on this rail, I didn't stop to see the station before my very eyes. It was a shabby locomotive stop in the middle of an empty wasteland. It had the equivalent value of a barren truckstop and the appearance of a desert gas station. No road led to this place. That didn't stop people from coming here. A long line of young men and women crowded this platform, standing and resting next to tall bags of luggage they carried. Together, the queue spilled out onto the dirt and stretched out for miles, far past the vanishing point in my line of sight. This wasn't the first peculiar sight for me to come across, and it was likely not going to be the last; so I kept on moving past the tracks.

Suddenly, I heard someone shout, "Get off the tracks!" It was the waiting conductor.

He looked tired out of his mind. The man was old and in the front of the line, waiting longer than any of the young adults behind. I couldn't help but feel sorry for this dreary, old man. Thinking about him made me feel exhausted. I stepped off the tracks and rested my feet on the edge of the platform.

"What are you all in line for?" I asked.

None of the people responded. I didn't know why. But they all seemed either unsure, or just plain indifferent.

The silence was finally interrupted by a timid girl near the edge of the platform. She was about a year or two older than me. "We're waiting for the train."

The conductor stepped in and faced me, eye to eye. "The train'll take them to a place far away from here. We have no place in this land anymore." The tired, old man looked back against the mile long line of teenagers, waiting on the dusty grounds of the wasteland, bored out of their minds.

"How long have you guys been waiting for this island train?"

The old man put his head down, having difficulty answering the question. He eventually stepped back in line and muttered out two words. "Nine months."

"Oh."

"The trains always pass us, never stopping for us to board. Sometimes, the kids get impatient and hop themselves on as stowaways while the carts are still running."

"And everyone else?"

"Most of them stay hopeful. Refusing to give up their place in line, out of fear that the train'll finally come once they step away."

"Even after nine months?"

The tired, old man nodded.

"I was on one of those trains actually." I said. "For nine months too."

The young girl popped her head out of the line and spoke up once more. This time, not so quietly. "You were on one of those trains!? They never stop though... how'd you get off?" She looked at the tracks, and then back at me. "WHY did you get off?"

“I jumped out the window while it was still going, nearly breaking my arm. It was the wrong train- I should’ve never got on in the first place.”

“And so now you’re just walking?” She raised an eyebrow, somewhat amazed and impressed by my statement.

“Sometimes, I run.”

The old man scoffed and interjected. “A vagabond. That’s what you’ve turned yourself into. And not to mention your heading the wrong way.

I looked back down the railroad, the way he had come from. “The sun’s setting on that side. I’m heading where the sun rises.”

“East? No one heads east. The trains come FROM east. Never TO.”

“And now you know why I’m walking.” I said, stepping off the platform to continue my journey down the railroad.

The tired, old man called out once more. “You don’t even have a backpack! Or food. Or water. How’re you gonna sleep... when the night comes.”

I was too far away at this point to hear anything from him. The tired, old man stepped back in line, muttering curse words to himself about that simple-minded, stubborn boy who had ticked him off.

Despite my outer apathy to the dangers of his situation, I truly was deeply afraid, especially of the night. More than the average person, I feared the night, specifically the dark. There was no tragic backstory for why I dreaded the pitch blackness of twilight. Maybe it was the sheer terror of not being able to see anything, even with your eyes open - combined with a childhood phobia that was never fully conquered. This was why I carried matches. One spark of light could turn a

stick and a piece of trash into a torch. And suddenly, the night would no longer be so dark. Unfortunately, my box was running low, and there was not a stick or trash can in sight.

I looked back and saw the sun, coming closer and closer to setting by the second. My footsteps doubled in pace as my heartbeat tripled. There was not a single resting stop in sight. I was almost sure to have seen a town far off to his right, but it wasn't worth the risk of going away from the tracks just to make sure. I refused to step away from that railroad for more than ten feet. I was already lost enough already.

A long field of tall, golden grass covered the rest of the horizon in my line of sight. For a split second, I thought I saw a wild animal - maybe a wolf - lurking from under the dry blades of grass. In the brightness of day, I felt no reason to fear the creature. This animal was stuck in the wilderness like me. Perhaps he or she was lost but still determined to find greener pastures. I wish that canine well. If our paths were to ever cross again, I hope for it to be a better circumstance, one where we wouldn't have to be weary of one another.

By now, it was making more and more sense to turn back to the shabby stop. If people had been waiting in line there for nine months, there must've been food, water, and warmth to be found there. Either that, or their luggage bags were much big enough to serve as human cocoons. I turned around to see how far back it was. All I could see was the setting sun, getting dangerously close to the horizon as it colored the sky with rose red and smoke grey. I suddenly found myself choking. It was unbelievable. I was fearing the approach of the dark more than the dark itself. I turned back once more, hoping that it was just the exaggeration of his phobia. The sun was now dipping past the horizon. But now, it wasn't the only thing in sight. There was now a silhouette of a person, running towards me.

Is it that tired, old conductor?

It was not the conductor, but instead the timid girl from the line. She had left her place in line...to come follow me? That was creepy, at least a bit to me. The girl waved her hand signaling for me to wait up. I only slowed my pace, refusing to stand still while a setting sun was behind me.

When she caught up and caught her breath, she looked up to me, waiting for me to say something.

“Is something wrong??”

Her eyes widened and she suddenly snapped, “OH. I’m sorry! She blushed. “It’s just that I sometimes forget to introduce myself when I meet people.”

“No worries.”

“It’s a little strange.”

“We’re all a little strange.”

“Tell me about it!” Annie laughed out loud. It turns out she wasn’t so quiet after all. She then reached out her hand towards me. “I’m Annie Day.”

I looked at her hand for a seemingly long second, almost surprised. It had been so long since another person had even offered to shake my hand. I politely obliged.

Soon after, I looked back at the sun - now half gone - and quickened his pace. Annie quickened hers too. Unlike myself, she carried a backpack. But she moved as if it were weightless.

“What’s going on here?”

“We need to get to a town before it’s too dark.”

“What comes out at dark?”

“I don’t know. Ghosts. Serial killers. Coyotes?”

“Coyotes? They don’t hunt people.”

“At least not in packs.”

“Oh.” This time, Annie quickened her pace. “So, why’re you going east?”

“Because I’m going home.”

“What?” Shouted Annie. She coughed and took a deep breath. “Home?”

“I was on that train for months. It was going God knows how fast. For all I know, I can be walking down these train tracks for the next thirty years. But as long as I stay by these tracks, I’ll be fine.”

She was too flabbergasted - and still somewhat amazed - to speak words now. “It took how many months for you to get here, and you still wanna walk back!?”

“Aren’t you doing that too? Isn’t that why you left the line?”

“Absolutely, no! I’m only going to another station.”

“You don’t miss your family?”

“I do... but... but- uh... it’s not worth sleeping on dirt where bugs and mice could crawl all over me. If there was a train that went east, I’d probably be going home too.”

I nodded. “I think a lot of people would.”

We continued our conversational stroll as the sun set, leaving us to be greeted by the cold night. A pitch black blanket overtook the atmosphere. It wasn’t too much of a disaster however. I had come across a dislocated trail bar and an empty cotton sack. It made the perfect torch. And two hours after that, Annie had found a new station to wait in. She made herself comfortable on one of the benches. Using her backpack as a pillow, she rocked herself to sleep. As for me, I figured it was best to not waste torchlight, so the next step was to keep on moving. Before I could go, I heard her speak to me one last time.

“What’s it like on the train?” said Annie. Her eyes were still shut.

I wasn’t sure of how to answer such a question, but I gave it my best shot. “Nobody ever talks. They just look down at their knees and ignore everyone else. It’s like they’re having a staring contest with their pants, or the floor, or something that’s apparently more interesting than friendship.”

To which she said, “Well, I’m sorry you got ignored by people who had staring contests with their pants.” She tried not to smirk at that sentence.

After a short, silent pause, she opened her eyes and reached into her backpack. Out of the bag, her arm pulled out a fresh, green apple. She handed it to me, and I couldn’t help but smile as I thanked her. To me, this was her way of saying *good luck*. She was the first friend I made since going on the train, and the only way to remember her was by an apple.

Nevertheless, it was a really good apple. It was the first food I had eaten in two days, and I didn’t even realize it was that long until after eating the entire thing down to the seeds and stem. I realized I was so hungry now. Upon noticing that, I also noticed how dehydrated I was. In fact, my mouth was completely parched. There had to be a drink of water nearby to find. But sadly, every shop was closed, and every well was blocked up. I did eventually find an old underground soup kitchen that happened to be open all night long. The water they served there may have been putrid — but it was still better than nothing. I downed that murky water and then asked if I could get a bottle or canteen or something, but they refused once they discovered I had no money.

Thankfully, I was able to walk out with an old pale. It was one they used to collect raindrops from the leaky roof. And since it wasn’t raining, those generous shopkeepers took enough pity to give the dehydrated boy before them some charity. With this achievement, I continued my journey.

The next day, I came across a peculiar sight. One I had not seen yet on my travels. A crossroad. It intersected through my railroad, heading north to a destination I couldn’t imagine. The two lines formed a grand ‘X’ on the ground, mounted on clean, dark gravel. As the signs barricading the center came down, a train heading north zoomed by inches away from my fingertips. It cast a harsh gust of wind against my unkempt hair. The thundering boom of its whistle shook me to my core as it passed, making me feel smaller than any hill or tree could.

One of the kids onboard - only a year or two younger than me - he stood by the window. For only a second or two, he stared at me, confused and concerned. He may have not wondered about the passengers of the other trains until this very moment. Perhaps the thought would escape him

immediately. This boy was going somewhere I'd never see. Two seconds of my life was spent on this north-heading railroad. But as for the kids on that locomotive, that railroad was their life. It made me wonder: *The stuff we pass on a train is so quick and brief, we don't even stop to realize that there's a whole new world in that direction.*

Yet in this moment, our two lives had crossed paths for a single brief moment, so I waved back, thinking out loud, *Godspeed! May your ride take you somewhere worthwhile.*

I hunched my shoulders and then hushed my inner thoughts to focus on the journey ahead. The east-facing railroad still seemed to go on forever. I still didn't know where I was. My confused self soon became lost in thought again. *Do you remember your last friend, Chris?* I thought to myself. *We used to always pretend to be superheroes by the church lawn near the mountain tunnels. Did he end up going on one of the trains that descended deep into the earth?*

I stopped to think.

Yeah, I wanted to go with him. But I was afraid of that train. Those ones never come out of the ground. They stay in their dark tunnels forever.

A similar decision was coming my way. With darkness on my mind, I found myself covered in the shadows of twilight, greeted only by the light of a crescent moon and a choir of crickets. Both of those hosts would fade from my senses as I approached a tall hill of rock and dead grass. Through that hill, the railroad continued... in a tunnel... A dark, underground tunnel. It took my breath away, for there was no sign of light at the end. I then examined the hill towering over my body. In comparison, I was as small to it as one of the night's crickets would have been to me. Mounting this feat of nature would be a marvel itself. Not only that, choosing to go over the tunnel would end up being an immense departure. Was it worth the risk of getting lost?

After gazing up at the hill, I looked back at the tunnel. I wouldn't survive in that dark chasm, especially when there was no sight of an end. The tunnel was also an enclosed space. A passing train would instantly turn me into human mulch. That was the only piece of logic necessary for the decision I was about to make.

“Yep. I’m going over the hill,” I said out loud, picking up my pale and then trudging up the steep hillslope, “I’ll find the train tracks once I get down from the hill.”

Upon finishing a treacherous climb to the summit, I saw before me a land of rolling hills. They stretched on for miles, never seeming to end. The train tracks were nowhere in sight. How could I possibly find it again if I continued moving forward?

“The railroad will likely show up on one of the dips. As long as I’m heading where the sun’s rising, I can still make it home.”

Sadly, there was no sign of any train tracks on any dip. I remained lost in that labyrinth of hills, far away from civilization - far away from home. There were streams for water and trees for shade, but there was no sign of a train. I couldn’t even remember what my old train looked like as the days passed.

One night, I lay down on the grass, starving to the point of excruciating pain. I kept on telling myself - over and over again - that if I just kept moving along, I would at least come across the railroad... or at least another person. Then all of a sudden, a bolt of truth came and struck me in the head. I had realized I was no different than the people blindly waiting in line for the nevercoming train. In reaction, I just sighed and gazed at the stars in the night sky. Despite the soul-sucking emptiness in my stomach and the sharp weakness in my bones, I felt peace staring into the night sky. It was actually beautiful, like a still ocean you could fall into if you leaned in hard enough. I forgot to light a torch, yet here I was facing the dark. It no longer seemed so scary. Amidst all the hurt, I could at least no longer worry about my long-lived childhood fear.

I grinned and rested my head against the dirt. Maybe tomorrow, I’d find my home waiting for me at the edge of another distant hill of green grass. I can picture it now, seeing all the familiar sights of that past life. And after a sprint down a field full of memories, I’d see the place I’d grown to love all these years. My family was likely not there anymore, but I’d be able to make a new life in that dusty hut I called home. Ready for the next day, I closed my eyes, no longer feeling so weak.